ser or estar

Both mean “is”. Ser says what something is. Estar says how or where it is right now.



ser

What it is: lasting



estar

How or where it is now

When to use ser

WHO OR WHAT: NAMES, JOBS

Soy piloto.
I’m a pilot.

WHERE SOMEONE IS FROM

Somos de California.
We’re from California.

WHAT SOMETHING IS LIKE

La casa **es** grande.
The house is big.

TIME AND DATES

Son las tres.
It’s three o’clock.

WHERE AN EVENT TAKES PLACE

La fiesta **es** en mi casa.
The party is at my house.

When to use estar

WHERE THINGS AND PEOPLE ARE

Estoy en casa.
I’m at home.

HOW SOMEONE FEELS

Está cansada.
She’s tired.

WHAT’S GOING ON RIGHT NOW

Estamos comiendo.
We’re eating.

HOW SOMETHING IS TODAY

La sopa **está** fría.
The soup is cold.

Watch out: the meaning changes

Es aburrido. He’s boring.	Está aburrido. He’s bored.
Es listo. He’s clever.	Está listo. He’s ready.
Es verde. It’s green.	Está verde. It’s not ripe yet.
Es seguro. It’s safe.	Está seguro. He’s sure.

A memory trick many teachers use: ser for **DOCTOR** (description, occupation, characteristic, time, origin, relationship), estar for **PLACE** (position, location, action, condition, emotion). Events are the exception: *la fiesta es en mi casa*.

SOURCES

- RAE–ASALE, Nueva gramática básica de la lengua española (2011): ser and estar (copulative verbs).